Preparing a Complete Performance

Interpretation, diagnosis, restart points, recovery and a sustained two-piece programme.

How to use these notes

Read alongside the lessons or keep beside your piano. Review the explanations, try the practice tasks, then use the checklist without on-screen hints. Listening and demonstrations are available in the app. Notation examples show the opening two bars; full songs are in the Songbook.

In this chapter

1. Make a performance plan
2. Find the cause of a difficult passage
3. Start from several places
4. Recover gracefully in performance
5. Sustain the whole performance
6. Dress rehearsal: It Is Well
7. Dress rehearsal: Come Thou Fount
8. A lyrical hymn and a confident hymn
9. Abide with Me and Blessed Assurance

1. Make a performance plan

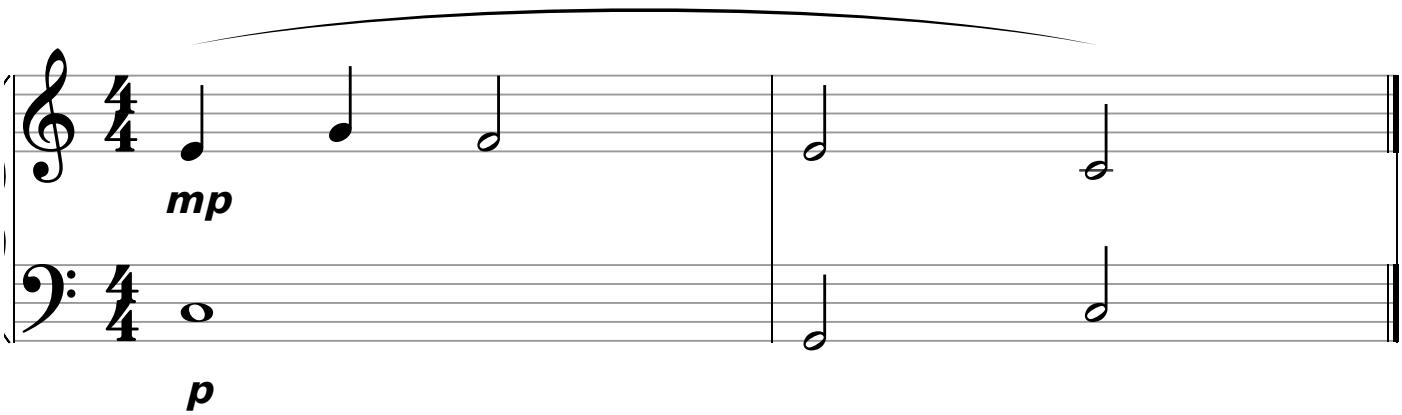
Choose tempo, phrase shapes and the character of each piece.

Make a performance plan

Before a final performance, choose two contrasting hymns: one lyrical and one with a confident pulse. Write down the key, comfortable tempo, phrase destinations and pedal plan. Choose a sound you can sustain through the whole piece. A slower coherent performance communicates more than a rushed one with frequent stops.

Practise · Choose a lyrical sound

Use this phrase to settle your balance and tone.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Listen and check

Describe the character in one sentence. Can another listener hear that intention, or is it only written in your plan?

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

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2. Find the cause of a difficult passage

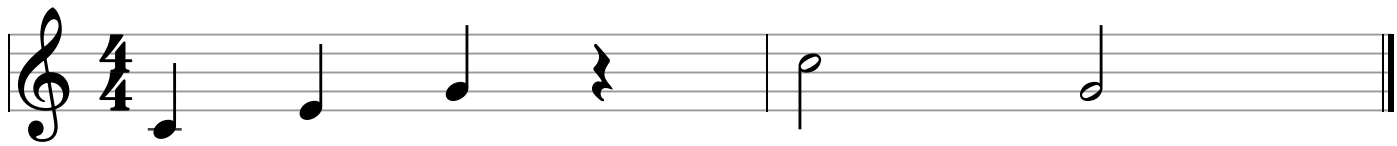
Separate reading, movement and rhythm problems.

Find the cause of a difficult passage

A difficult bar needs a diagnosis. If you cannot name the notes, read first. If the notes are known but the move fails, practise the landing silently. If hands alone work but together fail, tap the coordination. Loop two bars including the approach, not only the note that went wrong. Stop repeating when tension increases.

Practise · Prepare the landing

Use the rest to move the hand before the high note.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Coordination check

Tap this rhythm away from the keys before playing.

Listen and check

Write one specific cause and one specific solution. Replace play it again with an instruction such as prepare the thumb before beat three.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

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3. Start from several places
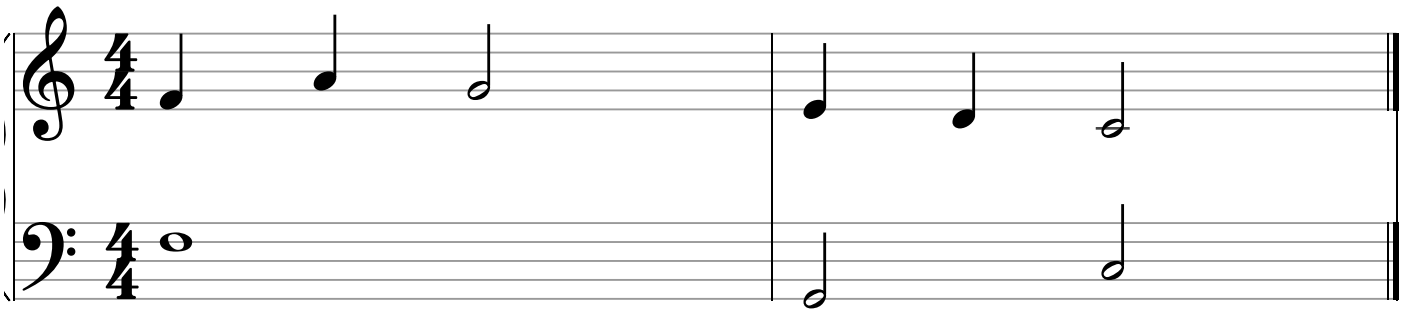
Build secure musical landmarks rather than one long chain.

Start from several places

Choose the beginning of each phrase and practise starting there without running in from the beginning. Name the first melody note, bass note and chord. Then join the last bar of one phrase to the next. This builds recovery points and checks whether you know the structure rather than only the finger sequence.

Practise · Start at phrase two

Prepare both starting notes before the count-in.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Join across the boundary

Make the arrival and new beginning part of one pulse.

Listen and check

Start your recital from three named phrase beginnings. The notation may stay available; secure reading and secure memory can support one another.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

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4. Recover gracefully in performance
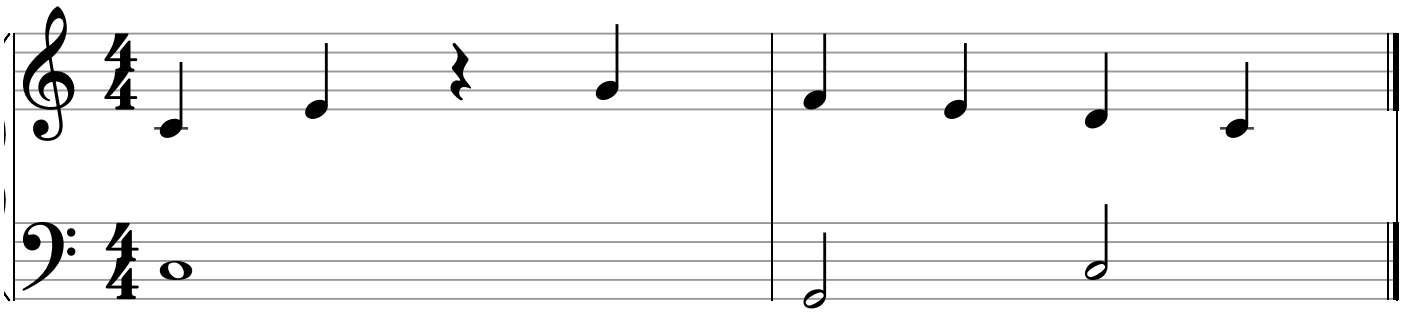
Keep time and rejoin at the next safe landmark.

Recover gracefully in performance

Practise recovery deliberately on an easy passage. During an offline run, leave out a melody note but keep counting and continue at the next beat. Do not practise errors repeatedly in the difficult passage itself. After the run, return to careful repair. A mistake is useful information rather than a reason to abandon the whole performance.

Practise · A planned gap

Count the written rest as a safe simulation of a missed note.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Listen and check

Could you keep the pulse through the gap? Choose a tempo at which you can continue calmly. Use Wait for repair and Flow for an uninterrupted timing rehearsal.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

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5. Sustain the whole performance
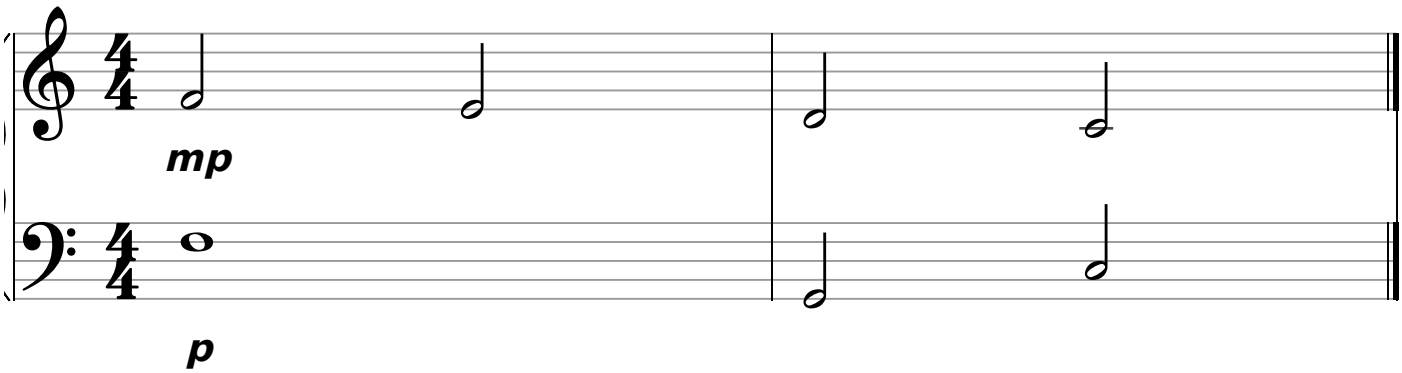
Prepare a final recital and reflect on what you hear.

Sustain the whole performance

Make the final rehearsal feel like a performance: settle the bench, take a breath, prepare the first notes and count in. Play both selected hymns with a short quiet pause between them. Afterwards, name one successful musical choice and one next goal. Judge the whole musical story as well as individual notes.

Practise · A settled final cadence

Finish the note fully and release both hands together.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Listen and check

Are both pieces comfortable at your chosen tempos? Can you keep the melody clear, recover from a small slip and finish without rushing? Return to the relevant chapter when one skill still needs support.

The app checks pitches. Use Flow for note-start timing; judge held notes, physical ease, balance and pedal by listening. Repeat a short passage before increasing speed.

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6. Dress rehearsal: It Is Well

Rehearse without stopping. Decide the phrase destinations and pedal changes before the first note.
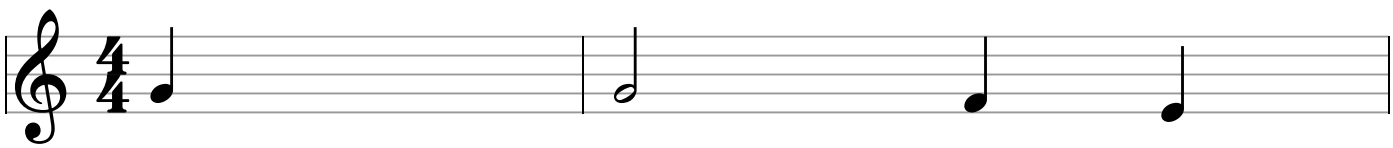
What to listen for

Rehearse without stopping. Decide the phrase destinations and pedal changes before the first note.

Prepare the opening with separate hands. Then use Play along, choose the hand you want to practise, and loop the troublesome bars. Count the pickup as bar 1 in the loop selector.

Practise · Melody alone

Rehearse without stopping. Decide the phrase destinations and pedal changes before the first note.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Accompaniment alone

Play the left hand softly. Count through the held notes and rests.

Practise · Opening together

Rehearse without stopping. Decide the phrase destinations and pedal changes before the first note.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: It Is Well

Rehearse without stopping. Decide the phrase destinations and pedal changes before the first note.

Your musical check

Afterwards name one successful musical choice and one passage needing repair.

Play again without the demonstration. Explain what you changed and whether it sounded better.

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7. Dress rehearsal: Come Thou Fount

Maintain a confident pulse through the whole hymn. Use planned phrase landmarks to recover calmly.
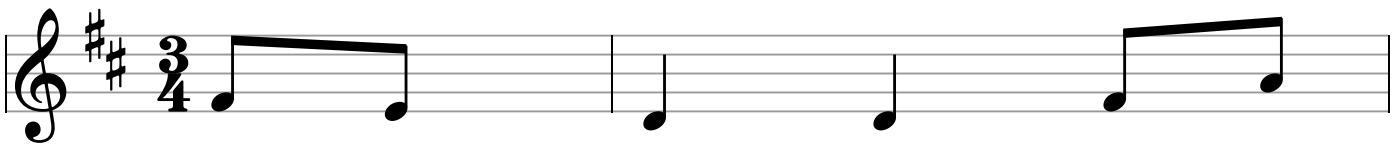
What to listen for

Maintain a confident pulse through the whole hymn. Use planned phrase landmarks to recover calmly.

Prepare the opening with separate hands. Then use Play along, choose the hand you want to practise, and loop the troublesome bars. Count the pickup as bar 1 in the loop selector.

Practise · Melody alone

Maintain a confident pulse through the whole hymn. Use planned phrase landmarks to recover calmly.



Opening example · 3/4 · D · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Accompaniment alone

Play the left hand softly. Count through the held notes and rests.

Practise · Opening together

Maintain a confident pulse through the whole hymn. Use planned phrase landmarks to recover calmly.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: Come Thou Fount

Maintain a confident pulse through the whole hymn. Use planned phrase landmarks to recover calmly.

Your musical check

Can you restart from three phrase beginnings without running in from the start?

Play again without the demonstration. Explain what you changed and whether it sounded better.

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8. A lyrical hymn and a confident hymn

Perform both complete hymns, with a short quiet pause between them. Keep the pulse, a clear melody, relaxed movement and a deliberate ending.

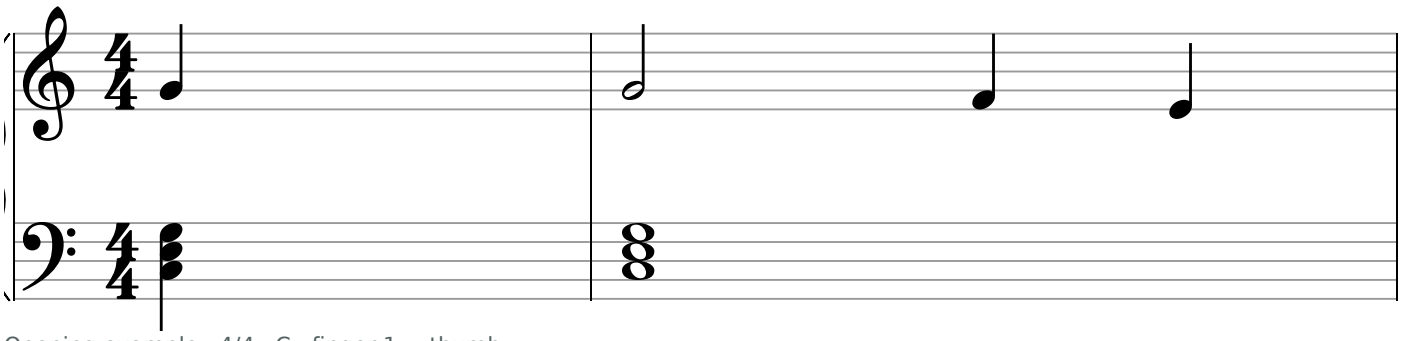
Prepare your recital

Perform both complete hymns, with a short quiet pause between them. Keep the pulse, a clear melody, relaxed movement and a deliberate ending.

Choose a comfortable tempo. Practise difficult bars separately, then reconnect them. Make one uninterrupted run before marking your recital complete. Completion records a play-through, not a certified grade.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: It Is Well with My Soul - final recital

Perform both complete hymns, with a short quiet pause between them. Keep the pulse, a clear melody, relaxed movement and a deliberate ending.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Dress rehearsal: Come Thou Fount - final recital

Perform both complete hymns, with a short quiet pause between them. Keep the pulse, a clear melody, relaxed movement and a deliberate ending.

Practise · Performance 1: It Is Well with My Soul - final recital

Take a breath, prepare the starting notes, and play through. Keep going after a small mistake. Perform both complete hymns, with a short quiet pause between them. Keep the pulse, a clear melody, relaxed movement and a deliberate ending.

Practise · Performance 2: Come Thou Fount - final recital

Take a breath, prepare the starting notes, and play through. Keep going after a small mistake. Perform both complete hymns, with a short quiet pause between them. Keep the pulse, a clear melody, relaxed movement and a deliberate ending.

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9. Abide with Me and Blessed Assurance

Perform both complete hymns with a short quiet pause between them. Contrast a calm singing line with a confident 9/8 pulse; keep the melody clear and recover at planned landmarks.

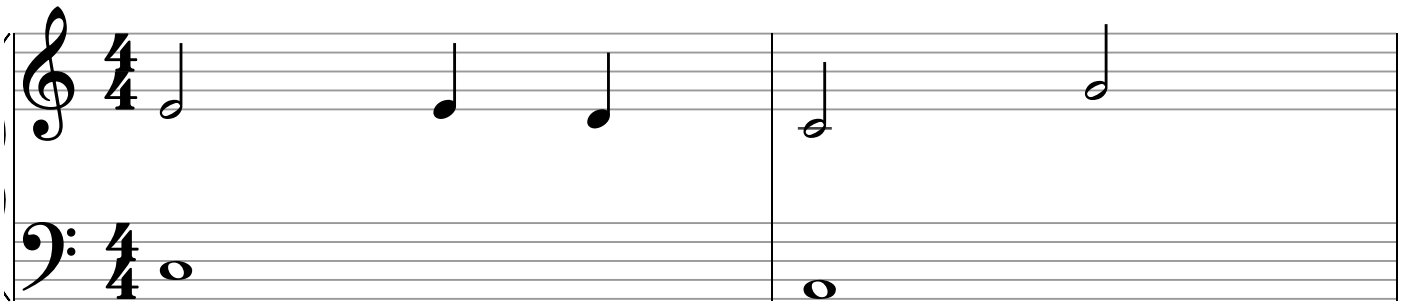
Prepare your recital

Perform both complete hymns with a short quiet pause between them. Contrast a calm singing line with a confident 9/8 pulse; keep the melody clear and recover at planned landmarks.

Choose a comfortable tempo. Practise difficult bars separately, then reconnect them. Make one uninterrupted run before marking your recital complete. Completion records a play-through, not a certified grade.

Practise · Dress rehearsal: Abide with Me

Perform both complete hymns with a short quiet pause between them. Contrast a calm singing line with a confident 9/8 pulse; keep the melody clear and recover at planned landmarks.



Opening example · 4/4 · C · finger 1 = thumb

Practise · Dress rehearsal: Blessed Assurance

Perform both complete hymns with a short quiet pause between them. Contrast a calm singing line with a confident 9/8 pulse; keep the melody clear and recover at planned landmarks.

Practise · Performance 1: Abide with Me

Take a breath, prepare the starting notes, and play through. Keep going after a small mistake. Perform both complete hymns with a short quiet pause between them. Contrast a calm singing line with a confident 9/8 pulse; keep the melody clear and recover at planned landmarks.

Practise · Performance 2: Blessed Assurance

Take a breath, prepare the starting notes, and play through. Keep going after a small mistake. Perform both complete hymns with a short quiet pause between them. Contrast a calm singing line with a confident 9/8 pulse; keep the melody clear and recover at planned landmarks.

Can I do this independently?

Try these at your piano with hints and note labels turned off. Tick a box when you can do it comfortably; return to the matching lesson when you need a reminder.

- [ ] Choose tempo, phrase shapes and the character of each piece.
- [ ] Separate reading, movement and rhythm problems.
- [ ] Build secure musical landmarks rather than one long chain.
- [ ] Keep time and rejoin at the next safe landmark.
- [ ] Prepare a final recital and reflect on what you hear.
- [ ] Perform my chosen recital with its stated musical goals, a clear melody, steady pulse and comfortable movement.

My next practice goal

What sounded better? What still needs work?
